finding it hard to chart a coherent policy in light of these differences. Soon after Amin's coup against Taraki in 1979, for example, Teja's political counselor opened a parallel line with the MEA in New Delhi and began contradicting Teja's assessments on Amin's longevity. Teja was confident that Amin was there to stay and had a friendly attitude towards India, whereas his counselor remained wary of Amin's crackdown.[124] According to the counselor, Amin was making enemies at a faster rate than building allies. This was unsustainable. The Soviet invasion proved the counselor right, much to Teja's embarrassment.

In December 1981, J. N. Dixit, Gandhi's confidante (who would become foreign secretary in the early 1990s and then national security advisor in 2005), was appointed ambassador to Kabul. Dixit unleashed a charm offensive with Karmal and Tabeev. An antithesis of Teja, Dixit gave the final push that operationalised India's pro-Parcham tilt. Dixit's close rapport with Babrak Karmal and Fikryat Tabeev made the Khalq doubtful of India's neutrality. In their meetings with Dixit, Khalqi leaders would be polite but non-committal towards India. They would seek to maintain friendly ties with New Delhi, but not expand them. Striking a balance between different political factions in Kabul became an enduring theme in India's Afghanistan policy debates since the 1980s. The rise of Hamid Karzai in the wake of US-led NATO intervention in 2001, for instance, created a similar dilemma for India, i.e. whether to throw its weight behind Karzai or to support the increasingly marginal (and disunited) politicians from the erstwhile anti-Taliban United Front?

## *Rajiv-Najib affair*

The second case underlining India's pro-Parcham tilt was Rajiv Gandhi's staunch support for Najibullah against all odds in the late 1980s. The Rajiv-Najibullah relationship evolved on political and personal levels, both of which reinforced each other. The first causal driver pushing Najibullah's case in New Delhi was his excellent relationship with Dixit between 1982 and 1985. Having met most potential candidates who were in line to replace Karmal, Dixit favoured Najibullah the most, despite knowing he represented the radical wing of Parcham that criticised Karmal's 'soft' approach toward Gulabzoi after the July 1980